8.6 Activities: the doorstroomtoets, calmly

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These activities are about feeling ready, not about more maths. Most take 10 minutes.

1. My “I can” list

You need: a card or nice sheet of paper, the progress tracker, the “I can” goals from units 8.1–8.5.

Together, read back through everything he has ticked off since groep 6. He chooses 8–10 things he is proud of and writes them on the card in his own words: “I can find 10% of anything.” “I can use a ratio table for speed.” “I can catch a wrong calculator answer.” Keep the card somewhere he’ll see it. He reads it on test morning.

Talk about it: “What could you do now that you couldn’t do in groep 6?”

2. Meet the real format

You need: Cito’s sample test (voorbeeldmateriaal), either the printed booklet or the online version; or the sample material for the test his school uses.

Week 4 of the plan. Sit together and **just look**. Find the maths section. Notice: what does a multiple-choice question look like? Where do you write an open answer? Are there pictures, tables, timetables? Then pick four or five maths questions he likes the look of and do them together, slowly. Stop there. You can do a few more on another day.

Talk about it: “Was there anything you’d never seen before? Anything that surprised you by being easy?”

3. Skip and come back

You need: practice Set 2 or 3.

Before starting, he reads through all the questions and puts a small star next to any that look hard. He does all the non-starred ones first, then comes back to the stars. Afterwards: were the starred ones as hard as they looked?

Talk about it: “How did it feel to leave a question and come back? Was it easier the second time?”

4. A test-style morning (rehearsal)

You need: practice Set 4, a quiet table, scrap paper, pencils, a glass of water.

Week 5. Set the scene like a test morning: phone away, a quiet room, the paper face down until he’s ready. He does the set in one sitting at his own pace. **No timer.** You sit nearby doing something quiet. When he’s done, check together and celebrate what went well before looking at anything that went wrong.

If he wants (only if he asks), on another day you can note the time at the start and the end, just to see that there is plenty of it. Never count down.

Talk about it: “What part of your toolkit did you use? What would you do the same on the real day?”

5. The calm kit

You need: nothing.

Practise three tools at home on ordinary days, so they're automatic on the test day:

- **Slow breathing.** In through the nose for a count of 4, out through the mouth for a count of 6. Twice.
- **Feet on the floor.** Notice both feet pressing on the floor, and the chair holding you up. 10 seconds.
- **A helpful sentence.** He chooses his own, for example "I've seen this kind of question before" or "One question at a time."

Talk about it: "Which one feels most useful to you? When could you use it outside of tests?"

6. Write your worries down (optional, try it first on an ordinary test)

You need: a sheet of paper, a pencil, 10 minutes, a bin.

Evidence caveat for the parent: writing about worries just before a test helped anxious students do better in a well-known study (Ramirez & Beilock, 2011), but it was done with older students, not with 11–12-year-olds. It may help him, or it may not. Treat it as an experiment, and stop if it makes him more upset. See the parent guide.

How to do it: before a normal school test (not the doorstroomtoets first), he writes for about 10 minutes about whatever he's worried about. Spelling doesn't matter. Nobody reads it unless he wants them to. Then he folds it up and throws it away, or keeps it, his choice.

Afterwards, ask: "Did that help, make no difference, or make it worse?" If it helped, he can use it on the morning of the doorstroomtoets. If not, drop it.

Talk about it: "Did your worries look bigger or smaller once they were on paper?"

Conversation prompts for these weeks

- "What's one thing you're looking forward to after the test?"
- "If a friend was nervous about the test, what would you tell them?"
- "What's in your toolkit for a hard question?"
- "The test can only make your advice go up. How does that make you feel about it?"